Unit One

1.1 Where the Mind is Without Fear...

Warming Up!

1. Pair up with your partner and match the terms with their given meanings.

Column 'A'	Column 'B'
(1) Humanism	(a) Concern about and action aimed at protecting the environment.
(2) Patriotism	(b) Holding liberal views.
(3) Internationalism	(c) Quality of being patriotic: vigorous support for one's country.
(4) Liberalism	(d) State or process of being international.
(5) Environmentalism	(e) A rationalistic outlook towards humans rather than a divine or supernatural one.

2. Poems in English are of different types.

- Sonnet
- Limerick
- Ballad
- Elegy
- Free verse
- Epic
- Lyric
- Humorous
- Idyll

Taking the help of a dictionary/internet guess and write the type of poem against its description.

(i) A long story-poem, often mythical .....

(ii) A short story poem with a message .....

(iii) A poem of 14 lines .....

(iv) A song-like poem .....

(v) A poem with no uniformity of rhyme, rhythm etc. .....

(vi) A poem set in picturesque, rustic background .....

(vii) A sad poem, lamenting death of a loved one .....

(viii) A 5-line short funny poem with rhyme-scheme aabba.

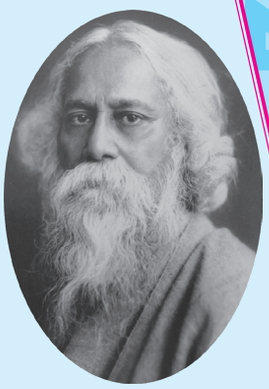
(ix) A poem written, just to create humour .....

Where the Mind is Without Fear...

Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941) was the author of Gitanjali and its 'profoundly sensitive, fresh and beautiful verse'. He became the first non-European to win the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913.

This poem is one of his vastly read and discussed poems. It was originally composed in Bengali and later he himself translated it into English. This poem is from his Nobel Prize winning anthology 'Gitanjali'.

Tagore lived during the time when India was ruled by the British. In this poem, besides political freedom from British, Tagore also appeals to God for social, educational and economic freedom for the people of India.



Where the mind is without fear and the head is held high
Where knowledge is free
Where the world has not been broken up into fragments
By **narrow domestic walls**
Where words come out from the depth of truth
Where **tireless striving stretches its arms** towards perfection
Where the clear stream of reason has not lost its way
Into the dreary desert sand of **dead habit**
Where the mind is led forward by Thee
Into **ever-widening** thought and action
Into that **heaven of freedom**, my Father, let my country awake.

– *Rabindranath Tagore*

- *What does the poet pray to the Almighty for?*
- *What are 'reason' and 'dead habit' compared to?*
- *What does the poet wish for?*

- **narrow domestic walls :** division on the basis of religion, caste, class and colour in societies and between countries of the world
- **tireless striving :** continuous efforts and struggle
- **stretches its arm :** aims at achieving a goal
- **dead habit :** old traditional rituals and customs that are harmful
- **ever-widening :** forever broadening one's outlook
- **heaven of freedom :** condition of total freedom of good thoughts, good words and good deeds, while respecting those of others

ENGLISH WORKSHOP

1. In your notebook write down lines from the poem as a proof for the following.

(a) Tagore wishes for a nation where people are truthful.

(b) The poet would like everyone to work hard to reach their goal and in the long run to reach perfection.

(c) The poet wishes that everyone in his country holds his head high in dignity.

(d) The poet dreams of a nation where knowledge should be free to all.

(e) The poem is a 'prayer'.

2. Read the columns carefully and match the expressions with their meanings.

No	Column A		Column B
(1)	The head is held high	(a)	A fearless person
(2)	Narrow domestic walls	(b)	Sincerity of heart
(3)	Knowledge is free	(c)	A person with self respect and proud of possessing it
(4)	Depth of truth	(d)	Narrow mindedness
(5)	Mind is without fear	(e)	Education is given to all
(6)	Stretches its arms	(f)	Dried up, infertile land of sands
(7)	Clear stream of reason	(g)	Clear thinking
(8)	Dead habits	(h)	Aim at perfection
(9)	Ever widening thought and action	(i)	Broadening the outlook and attitude

(1) ..... (2) ..... (3)..... (4) ..... (5) ..... (6) ..... (7) ..... (8) ..... (9) .....

3. (A) Answer the following questions in your own words.

(a) How is the world broken into fragments?

(b) Explain what the 'tireless striving' should, be for.

(c) 'Where words come out from the depth of truth.' Explain in your own words.

(d) Who is 'Thee' in the poem? What does the poet appeal to 'Thee' to do?

(e) What qualities does the poet wish to inculcate in his countrymen?

(B) Write in your notebook your own response and justify, where needed.

(a) Is the poem a prayer for India alone?

(b) What should the words we speak reflect?

(c) What should people keep on widening? How can it be done?

(d) From what darkness of night should our nation awake?

(e) What attributes of Rabindranath Tagore does the poem (prayer) reflect?

(f) What effect does the repetition of the word 'where' at the begining of each line?

4. Read the poem carefully and complete the table after the discussion in pairs. One is done for you.

Concepts in the poem	Present situation	Expected/ideal situation
(1) mind	mind is full of fear	fearless mind
(2) head	.....	.....
(3) knowledge	.....	.....
(4) words	.....	.....
(5) habit	.....	.....
(6) thought and action	.....	.....

5. (A) Complete the following sentences using your own interpretation.

(a) When the mind is without fear and head unbowed, we enjoy ..... freedom.

(b) When knowledge is free, every citizen enjoys the right to ..... and .....

(c) We can prevent ..... injustice when we pull down discriminatory walls of caste, class, religion etc.

(d) Constant effort and strife leads to .....

(e) Logical thinking and reasoning can put a stop to ..... .

(f) Tagore appeals to God to make his country a .....

(B) Fill in the blanks.

(a) Students should keep themselves aloof from ..... .

(b) When ..... everyone will be literate.

(c) It is a social duty of every student of the modern world to uproot ..... from societies.

(d) Students must develop ..... outlook and attitudes.

(e) In the world of sycophancy, students must ..... .

6. Find out the examples of 'Metaphor' from the poem.

7. Almost every line of the poem begins with the word 'Where' and it expects an idealistic country and countrymen. Now work in a group of six students and compose your poem regarding 'Ideal School'. Begin your lines with the word 'Where' . . . . .

8. Read the poem. Write an Appreciation of the poem in about 12 to 15 sentences with the help of the following points. Use a paragraph format.

Points

- Title
- Poet
- Rhyme scheme

- Favourite line
- Theme/Central idea
- Figures of speech
- Special features - Type of the poem, language, tone, implied meaning, etc.
- Why I like/ dislike the poem

9. Imagine that you have to deliver a speech on the occasion of 'Independence Day' or the 'Republic Day' in the school assembly. Prepare a speech to deliver on 'India of my dreams'

Use the following steps :

- Greeting and salutation
- Self Introduction
- Introduction of the topic
- Elaboration of the topic with examples
- Conclusion
- Thanking audience

10. Read the short story written by Rabindranath Tagore 'The Kabuliwala' or 'The Home Coming.'

Visit the website and collect more information about Rabindranath Tagore's life and work.

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